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Virginia Board of Education, Emergency Meeting, Thursday, May 11, 2023

Date	Thursday, May 11, 2023
Place	Virginia Board of Education (Virginia Department of Education), Richmond, Virginia
Length	12m (video)

- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mZbyZmrUlgs
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-23. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:03:09] All right, we are going to convene the emergency meeting of the Board of Ed, you know, pursuant to statute 2.2-3707D of the Code of Virginia. We have the authority to call an emergency meeting.

[00:03:26] That was done yesterday afternoon. There have been some issues that have been publicly raised about the backlog and teacher licensure. And what we hope to do today is to address hopefully approve an item to uh help through that uh that issue so i'm going to turn this over item a to dr coons yes thank you um i appreciate the opportunity to provide this item for you for first and final of emergency regulations to amend licensure regulations of school personnel

[00:03:59] to extend the expiration of renewable licenses um we have experienced unprecedented licensure changes and backlogs over the past several years during the pandemic renewable licenses were extended several times which has created an end date right now we are getting ready to launch a fully cadillac version of a digital platform that we can launch in the fall we want to give our educators the opportunity to use a high quality renewal system it is within statute as statute has

[00:04:35] moved from a five-year renewal to a 10-year renewal process and we want to afford the opportunity for that 10-year renewal and that extended renewal for all of our educators who are working diligently to support children it is my first priority to look at some of these things we know that we need a

high quality licensed teacher in every k-12 classroom and that has been my first initiative as superintendent and this is one area that allows us to continue to focus on that work and ensure that we are elevating teachers, that we are looking at ways to put more teachers and high quality licensed teachers in classrooms. So I appreciate the review and I hope that we can have

[00:05:12] a motion on waiving the first review and approve emergency regulation and delegate to the superintendent, the authority to carry out the requirements. So I'm hoping that we can get into that space and have a conversation. Actually, before we have the discussion, let me fulfill the bylaw obligation. We have a quorum physically assembled here in one place, and we have participating remotely, Dr. Davis Faught, Mr. Rotherham, and Mr. Certifan, all of whom I have approved in accordance with our bylaws. Okay, now, are there any questions, comments? Not a question,

[00:05:49] but just a comment by way of, well, actually a question as well, but a comment by way of thank you, Dr. Coons, to focus and make as absolutely the facts dictate that our teacher shortage issues your top priority, and I welcome, I've heard you say that now in several different contexts, and it is really a crisis where our divisions are dealing with, and I appreciate your recognition of its importance, and you're stepping in so quickly to treat it like a crisis and to recognize that there's something within the division and the department and the

[00:06:26] board's control that we can do to help address it, that we should do so on an emergency basis. And I'm just grateful to you for bringing this to our attention and bringing this opportunity to help the divisions along the way a little to us today. The question would be at some appropriate moment, whether now is it or not, we'd love to hear just your update on whatever else you're able to share about what you're doing more broadly to address the licensure crisis.

[00:06:56] And if you've got anything else, you're ready to share about the broader teacher shortage issues. Absolutely. So I was able to attend the VAS conference and speak with several superintendents at that meeting and heard very clearly that we needed to elevate this work and move it very quickly. That following Friday, we had a meeting with the leadership team at VAS.

[00:07:18] We also have reinstituted the task force on teacher licensure and had a combined meeting with that group, took recommendations from them. This is one of the pieces that came from those recommendations. And then we also are working with school division superintendents. We have a meeting tomorrow to talk about ways to elevate their authority, just like this is an elevation of the board's authority to help us streamline that process.

[00:07:46] We also have reorganized the way in which we process licenses until that new Cadillac program is instituted, and we are reaching out to retired and part-time HR specialists to build out our staff to make sure that we can process licenses and make sure that all of the licenses that are pending are back on track no later than July 1st.

[00:08:09] So there are a lot of different internal pieces, but also working with our school divisions in partnership to make sure that we are all working together and excited to have an all-call school division superintendent meeting tomorrow afternoon to talk with them about some options that we're going to put in place for them as well.

[00:08:28] Thank you. Anybody else? Mr. President. Yes, sir. Mr. Sertifan. You know, I believe like most board members are getting things done. And when I saw this email from Dr. Coons, I was very pleased to

know that she is definitely on a mission to get some things done in the Commonwealth. And anything that we can do to get these license approved and push forward, I'm 100% behind it. So Dr. Coons, I want to thank you for the effort you put into this.

[00:09:01] anybody else um mr president i would like to sincerely echo my appreciation for moving on this issue um it's one that has been on my radar for a couple of months now um but i would also just like to remind those remind everyone here of the serious number of teachers that we have that are licensed, seeking renewal, but may or may not be in a local school division. So, you know,

[00:09:36] it's important to get this information out to them as well, because they're walking this journey alone. Those who are currently working in school divisions do have, you know, that hand to hold, but we do have quite a few who are not employed. And so, for one reason or the other, but just wanted to remind us of that as well, and this is gonna be a huge help to them.

[00:10:05] - And we are working very closely with our communications team. I have given my secretary down to the team to make sure that she is working full-time with the HR team to make sure we're communicating with those school divisions and those individuals in the licensure process, and we will be launching a teacher support line as well for those individuals who may not have the support of a higher education if they're doing their initial license or renewal or anybody in that provisional space. So we are definitely one of those internal strategies is building out a communications pod inside the HR team to make sure we're being responsive. So

[00:10:42] appreciate that call out and I apologize for not mentioning that specifically. Thank you. Okay. Then is there a motion to waive first review and approve the emergency regulation which will have the effect of basically allowing the administrative extension of licenses to June 30, 2024. Is there a motion? Did I do that already? Did I miss it? And seconded by Mr. Hanson, thank you. All in favor signify by saying aye. Aye. Okay. Any opposed? That carries. Thank you

[00:11:21] all very much. I would like to echo Mr. Sturdivant's comments, Dr. Coons. It is particularly gratifying to have an item as important as this be enacted upon this quickly. And I'm not taken away from your role in this, but I do understand it was a fairly extensive team effort in the last couple of days to figure out a way to make this happen. And I know the impetus came from you and we are appreciative and like to thank everybody else who was involved with this and resolving at least temporarily this incredibly important issue for the Commonwealth. With that, We are adjourned.

[00:11:56] Thank you all for being here. Thank you. Goodbye.

